

SHORT-CHANGED?
Nagar Singh Chouhan

MADHYA PRADESH

A MINISTER REBELS

By Rahul Noronha

Crisis brings understanding. The ruling BJP has tamped down on the row emanating from a minister's rebellion, but it has left it acutely aware of the price it is paying for favouring defectors over party loyals. The story began in a mundane manner: on July 21, Ramniwas Rawat, a six-term Congress MLA who had switched to the BJP before the Lok Sabha election, was allotted the forests and environment portfolio in the Mohan Yadav cabinet. It was a reward for delivering Morena–the Lok Sabha seat where the BJP was faced with a tough fight. So far, so normal.

But the very next day, Nagar Singh Chouhan, a tribal leader from Alirajpur, raised a banner of revolt. To satiate Rawat, it was Chouhan, a four-term BJP MLA and first-time minister, who had been divested of forests and environment, a crucial portfolio in the state, leaving him with only SC welfare. When he threatened resignation, arguing that his ability to serve tribal interests had been compromised, political watchers were taken aback at his outspokenness. Rewarding turncoats has been a feature of BJP politics in the past four years; none had dared to question it so openly. Chouhan was summoned to Delhi where, on July 23, he met state BJP president V.D. Sharma and other senior leaders who assured him that his grievances would be addressed. The same day, Chouhan flew down to Bhopal with his MP wife Anita and Sharma, and met the CM. After the meeting that lasted some hours, he raised the proverbial white flag. Sources say Chouhan was asked to wait till the next reshuffle in which a heavier portfolio may come his way.

Chouhan's mini mutiny, which he tried to frame as an issue of tribal pride (hailing from Alirajpur in the western region, where two LS seats and 21 of the 47 assembly segments are ST-reserved), has highlighted the discontent within the BJP over the rewarding of outsiders. In the 32-member state cabinet, six ministers are recent Congress imports.

In 2020, when the defection of 22 Congress MLAs pulled down the Kamal Nath government, 14 of them were given ministerial berths. Then, the BJP needed their support to form the government. Now, with 164 MLAs in a 230-member House, the party is on a firm footing. A sizeable number of senior BJP MLAs, including Bhupendra Singh, Gopal Bhargava, Jayant Malaiya and Archana Chitnis, have been denied cabinet positions, yet the process of rewarding defectors continues. Sources say Kamlesh Shah, ex-Congress MLA from Amarwara who joined the BJP during the LS polls, is likely to be inducted into the cabinet, adding to the heartburn. He managed to scrape through a recent bypoll; sources suggest the Chouhan episode could delay his induction by a few months. ■



By Rahul Noronha

Recent explorations by historians and archaeologists in the Bandhavgarh National Park have shone a torch on the hitherto unlit history—rather, prehistory—of the Baghelkhand region in eastern Madhya Pradesh. The groundbreaking findings fill out the story of humankind in India.

Historically, archaeological research into India's ancient past has invariably tended to focus on urban centres. This extensive project marked a departure—for the first time, it took the tools of archaeology right into the core area of a designated tiger reserve. The results were fascinating: numerous sites yielded prehistoric stone tools, evidence of habitation from circa 5000 BC or even earlier. The material record from Bandhavgarh had been scanty—only going back to 200 AD—but the dating was by itself not a cause of astonishment. The Narmada basin to its south shows very early human presence, so do other sites on the Kaimur range, in which the reserve falls. What was breathtaking was the wealth of evidence on the